

Chapter 3 — Karma Yoga

कर्मयोगः : కర్మయోగము

"The Yoga of Action" · 43 verses · Detailed verse-by-verse edition with Ādi-Śaṅkara's Bhāṣya

Arjuna's natural reaction to Chapter 2 is: *"If knowledge (buddhi) is supreme, why must I act at all? Why not just renounce?"*

Kṛṣṇa's answer is uncompromising: **"No one can remain even for a moment without action."** The choice is never between acting and not-acting — it is between acting *selfishly* and acting *as offering* (yajña), without attachment, for the welfare of all (loka-saṅgraha).

Śaṅkara's frame: This whole chapter establishes his central doctrine — *karma-yoga purifies the mind (sattva-śuddhi) and is the means for the not-yet-qualified; jñāna alone liberates*. Knowledge and action are two distinct paths (Ch 3.3) for two distinct qualifications (adhikāra), never to be mixed (jñāna-karma-samuccaya-niṣedha).

Devanāgarī

IAST

English translation

Śaṅkara's Bhāṣya (explanation)

§ 1 · Arjuna's doubt & why action is unavoidable (3.1–3.9)

BG 3.1 Arjuna: if knowledge is better, why push me to this dreadful war?

अर्जुन उवाच ।

ज्यायसी चेत्कर्मणस्ते मता बुद्धिर्जनार्दन ।

तत्किं कर्मणि घोरे मां नियोजयसि केशव ॥ ३.१ ॥

arjuna uvāca | jyāyasī cet karmaṇas te matā buddhir janārdana |

tat kiṁ karmaṇi ghore māṁ niyojayasi keśava ||

Arjuna: "If You consider knowledge superior to action, O Janārdana, then why do You urge me to this ghastly action, O Keśava?"

Bhāṣya: Arjuna has rightly grasped that knowledge and action, opposed like light and dark, cannot both be the direct means to liberation for the same person. His error is only in thinking they are rival options for himself now. This verse opens Śaṅkara's discussion of the *non-combinability* of knowledge and action.

BG 3.2 "Tell me the one decisive path"

व्यामिश्रेणेव वाक्येन बुद्धिं मोहयसीव मे ।

तदेकं वद निश्चित्य येन श्रेयोऽहमाप्नुयाम् ॥ ३.२ ॥

vyāmiśreṇeva vākyaena buddhiṁ mohayaśīva me |

tad ekaṁ vada niścitya yena śreyo 'ham āpnuyām ||

"With seemingly mixed statements You confuse my understanding. Tell me decisively the one thing by which I may attain the highest good."

Bhāṣya: The teaching only *seemed* mixed to Arjuna's confusion. The two paths are meant for two classes of seeker — the unpurified (action) and the purified (knowledge) — not blended into one.

BG 3.3 □ Two distinct paths for two qualifications

श्रीभगवानुवाच ।

लोकेऽस्मिद्विविधा निष्ठा पुरा प्रोक्ता मयानघ ।

ज्ञानयोगेन साङ्ख्यानं कर्मयोगेन योगिनाम् ॥ ३.३ ॥

*śrī-bhagavān uvāca | loke 'smin dvividhā niṣṭhā purā proktā mayānagha |
jñāna-yogena sāṅkhyānām karma-yogena yoginām ||*

The Lord: "In this world a twofold path was taught by Me of old, O sinless one: the *jñāna-yoga* of the Sāṅkhyas (contemplatives) and the *karma-yoga* of the yogins (active seekers)."

Bhāṣya: A keystone verse. **Two distinct niṣṭhās** (steadfast paths) for two distinct qualifications: knowledge for those already fit (renunciants), action for the active seeker not yet purified. Because they are *two*, they cannot be *one combined* path — this is Śaṅkara's refutation of *samuccaya*.

BG 3.4 Neither mere abstention nor mere renunciation liberates

न कर्मणामनारम्भान्नैष्कर्म्यं पुरुषोऽश्नुते ।

न च संन्यसनादेव सिद्धिं समधिगच्छति ॥ ३.४ ॥

*na karmaṇām anārambhān naiṣkarmyaṁ puruṣo 'śnute |
na ca saṁnyasanād eva siddhiṁ samadhigacchati ||*

"Not by abstaining from actions does a man attain actionlessness; nor by mere renunciation does he reach perfection."

Bhāṣya: *Naiṣkarmya* (the actionless state = freedom) is not won by simply not-starting work, nor by outwardly dropping it. True actionlessness comes from **knowledge of the Self as non-doer**, not from idleness.

BG 3.5 □ You cannot escape action — even for a moment

न हि कश्चित्क्षणमपि जातु तिष्ठत्यकर्मकृत् ।

कार्यते ह्यवशः कर्म सर्वः प्रकृतिजैर्गुणैः ॥ ३.५ ॥

*na hi kaścit kṣaṇam api jātu tiṣṭhaty akarma-kṛt |
kāryate hy avaśaḥ karma sarvaḥ prakṛti-jair guṇaiḥ ||*

"No one can remain, even for a moment, without performing action. All are compelled to act, helplessly, by the qualities (guṇas) born of nature."

Bhāṣya: Why abstention fails — so long as one is embodied and identified with prakṛti, the three guṇas (sattva, rajas, tamas) force activity. "Sitting still" is an illusion of inaction. This is why Arjuna cannot escape by walking away.

BG 3.6 The hypocrite (mithyācāra)

कर्मन्द्रियाणि संयम्य य आस्ते मनसा स्मरन् ।

इन्द्रियार्थान्विमूढात्मा मिथ्याचारः स उच्यते ॥ ३.६ ॥

*karmendriyāṇi saṁyamya ya āste manasā smaran |
indriyārthān vimūḍhātmā mithyācāraḥ sa ucyate ||*

"He who restrains the organs of action but sits dwelling in his mind on the objects of the senses — that deluded one is called a hypocrite."

Bhāṣya: A pointed attack on *false* renunciation. Stilling the body while the mind chases sense-objects is self-deception — worse than useless.

§ 2 · The wheel of yajña — cosmic reciprocity (3.10–3.16)

BG 3.10 *Creation woven with sacrifice*

सहयज्ञाः प्रजाः सृष्ट्वा पुरोवाच प्रजापतिः ।

अनेन प्रसविष्यध्वमेष वोऽस्त्विष्टकामधुक् ॥ ३.१० ॥

saha-yajñāḥ prajāḥ sṛṣṭvā purovāca prajāpatiḥ |

anena prasaviṣyadhvam eṣa vo 'stv iṣṭa-kāma-dhuk | |

"In the beginning, Prajāpati created beings together with sacrifice, and said: 'By this shall you multiply; let this be the cow that yields all desires.'"

Bhāṣya: Yajña — duty rightly done — is woven into creation itself. Śaṅkara reads it broadly: fulfilling one's ordained duty is the yajña that sustains all.

BG 3.11 *Mutual nourishment*

देवान्भावयतानेन ते देवा भावयन्तु वः ।

परस्परं भावयन्तः श्रेयः परमवाप्स्यथ ॥ ३.११ ॥

devān bhāvayatānena te devā bhāvayantu vaḥ |

parasparam bhāvayantaḥ śreyaḥ param avāpsyatha | |

"Nourish the gods with this, and let the gods nourish you; nourishing one another, you shall attain the highest good."

Bhāṣya: A cosmic economy of mutual sustenance. Acting only for oneself breaks this reciprocity; duty-as-offering keeps the wheel turning and leads to *śreyas*.

BG 3.12 *The one who only takes is a thief*

इष्टान्भोगान् हि वो देवा दास्यन्ते यज्ञभाविताः ।

तैर्दत्तान्प्रदायैभ्यो यो भुङ्क्ते स्तेन एव सः ॥ ३.१२ ॥

iṣṭān bhogān hi vo devā dāsyante yajña-bhāvitāḥ |

tair dattān apradāyaibhyo yo bhuṅkte stena eva saḥ | |

"Nourished by sacrifice, the gods will give you desired enjoyments. But he who enjoys their gifts without giving back is verily a thief."

Bhāṣya: One who takes from the cosmic order (nature, gods, society) yet gives nothing back — no offering, no duty — is a *thief*. Selfish consumption is a violation.

BG 3.13 *The good eat the remnant of sacrifice*

यज्ञशिष्टाशिनः सन्तो मुच्यन्ते सर्वकिल्बिषैः ।

भुञ्जते ते त्वघं पापा ये पचन्त्यात्मकारणात् ॥ ३.१३ ॥

yajña-śiṣṭāśinaḥ santo mucyante sarva-kilbiṣaiḥ |

bhuñjate te tv agham pāpā ye pacanty ātma-kāraṇāt | |

"The good, who eat the remnants of sacrifice, are freed from all sins. But the wicked, who cook only for themselves, eat only sin."

Bhāṣya: Those who first offer, then partake of the "remnant," are purified. Those who act purely for their own sake consume *pāpa*. The inner attitude — offering vs. grabbing — purifies or pollutes.

अन्नाद्भवन्ति भूतानि पर्जन्यादन्नसम्भवः ।
यज्ञाद्भवति पर्जन्यो यज्ञः कर्मसमुद्भवः ॥ ३.१४ ॥

annād bhavanti bhūtāni parjanyaḍ anna-sambhavaḥ |
yajñād bhavati parjanyaḍ yajñaḥ karma-samudbhavaḥ ||

"From food beings come to be; from rain, food is produced; from sacrifice comes rain; and sacrifice is born of action."

Bhāṣya: He traces the chain: food → beings, rain → food, yajña → rain, action → yajña. Thus *action* stands at the base of the whole life-supporting cycle.

कर्म ब्रह्मोद्भवं विद्धि ब्रह्माक्षरसमुद्भवम् ।
तस्मात्सर्वगतं ब्रह्म नित्यं यज्ञे प्रतिष्ठितम् ॥ ३.१५ ॥

karma brahmōdbhavaḥṁ viddhi brahmākṣara-samudbhavam |
tasmāt sarva-gataḥṁ brahma nityaḥṁ yajñe pratiṣṭhitam ||

"Know that action arises from Brahman (the Veda), and Brahman springs from the Imperishable. Therefore the all-pervading Brahman is ever established in sacrifice."

Bhāṣya: Śaṅkara reads *brahma* here as the **Veda** (which prescribes action), issuing from the *Akṣara* (the Imperishable). So prescribed action has scriptural authority; the Veda-ordained order rests on *yajña*.

एवं प्रवर्तितं चक्रं नानुवर्तयतीह यः ।
अघायुरिन्द्रियारामो मोघं पार्थ स जीवति ॥ ३.१६ ॥

evaḥṁ pravartitaḥṁ cakraḥṁ nānuvartayatīha yaḥ |
aghāyur indriyārāmo moghaḥṁ pārtha sa jīvati ||

"He who does not follow the wheel thus set in motion — living in sin, delighting in the senses — lives in vain, O Pārtha."

Bhāṣya: Refusing to take part in the wheel of duty/offering, merely indulging the senses, is a sinful and purposeless life. Participation in ordained action is a moral and cosmic obligation for the unliberated.

§ 3 · The liberated sage & loka-saṅgraha (3.17–3.24)

BG 3.17 □ *The Self-knower has no remaining duty*

यस्त्वात्मरतिरेव स्यादात्मतृप्तश्च मानवः ।

आत्मन्येव च सन्तुष्टस्तस्य कार्यं न विद्यते ॥ ३.१७ ॥

yas tv ātma-ratir eva syād ātma-tṛptaś ca mānavaḥ |
ātmany eva ca santuṣṭas tasya kāryam na vidyate ||

"But the man who delights only in the Self, is satisfied with the Self, and is content in the Self alone — for him there is nothing that needs to be done."

Bhāṣya: The crucial exception. The Self-knower has **no remaining duty**, because duty exists to purify the mind, and his mind is already fulfilled. He is beyond karma-yoga; the goal is reached.

BG 3.18 □ *He gains nothing by acting, loses nothing by not-acting*

नैव तस्य कृतेनार्थो नाकृतेनेह कश्चन ।

न चास्य सर्वभूतेषु कश्चिदर्थव्यपाश्रयः ॥ ३.१८ ॥

naiva tasya kṛtenārtho nākṛteneha kaścana |
na cāsyā sarva-bhūteṣu kaścid artha-vyapāśrayaḥ ||

"For him there is no gain from action done, nor any loss from action not done; he depends on no being for any purpose."

Bhāṣya: The realized one has nothing to acquire or lose by action. This confirms that prescribed action is *not binding* on the liberated — its whole purpose is complete.

BG 3.19 □ *Therefore act unattached — and reach the Supreme*

तस्मादसक्तः सततं कार्यं कर्म समाचर ।

असक्तो ह्याचरन्कर्म परमाप्नोति पूरुषः ॥ ३.१९ ॥

tasmād asaktaḥ satataṁ kāryam karma samācara |
asakto hy ācaran karma param āpnoti pūruṣaḥ ||

"Therefore, always perform your duty without attachment; for by performing action unattached, a man attains the Supreme."

Bhāṣya: Since Arjuna is not yet the Self-knower, he must act — but *unattached*. Attachment-free action purifies the mind, which leads to knowledge, which leads to the Supreme. Action is the **indirect** means; knowledge the direct one.

BG 3.20 □ *Janaka and the welfare of the world*

कर्मणैव हि संसिद्धिमास्थिता जनकादयः ।

लोकसङ्ग्रहमेवापि सम्पश्यन्कर्तुमर्हसि ॥ ३.२० ॥

karmaṇaiva hi saṁsiddhim āsthitā janakādayaḥ |
loka-saṅgraham evāpi sampāśyan kartum arhasi ||

"Even Janaka and others attained perfection through action alone. You should act, too, with a view to the welfare of the world (loka-saṅgraha)."

Bhāṣya: Two motives to act: if unpurified, to reach perfection through action (like Janaka); even if already wise, to set an example. Śaṅkara reads Janaka as either purified through karma or a knower who kept acting for the world.

BG 3.21

The great set the standard others follow

यद्यदाचरति श्रेष्ठस्तत्तदेवेतरो जनः ।

स यत्प्रमाणं कुरुते लोकस्तदनुवर्तते ॥ ३.२१ ॥

yad yad ācarati śreṣṭhas tat tad evetaro janah |
sa yat pramāṇam kurute lokas tad anuvartate ||

"Whatever a great man does, others follow; whatever standard he sets, the world pursues it."

Bhāṣya: The rationale for *loka-saṅgraha*: the conduct of the eminent becomes the norm. Hence even a knower should act rightly, lest his abstention mislead the many.

BG 3.22

The Lord Himself has nothing to gain, yet acts

न मे पार्थास्ति कर्तव्यं त्रिषु लोकेषु किञ्चन ।

नानवाप्तमवाप्तव्यं वर्त एव च कर्मणि ॥ ३.२२ ॥

na me pārthāsti kartavyam triṣu lokeṣu kiñcana |
nānavāptam avāptavyam varta eva ca karmaṇi ||

"O Pārtha, there is nothing in the three worlds that I need to do, nothing unattained that I must attain — yet I engage in action."

Bhāṣya: Kṛṣṇa, the ever-fulfilled Lord, has no personal need to act — the supreme example — and yet He acts. The model: act for the world, not from need.

BG 3.23

If even I stopped, all would imitate My inaction

यदि ह्यहं न वर्तेयं जातु कर्मण्यतन्द्रितः ।

मम वर्त्मानुवर्तन्ते मनुष्याः पार्थ सर्वशः ॥ ३.२३ ॥

yadi hy ahaṁ na varteyaṁ jātu karmaṇy atandritaḥ |
mama vartmānuvartante manuṣyāḥ pārtha sarvaśaḥ ||

"For if I did not engage in action, unwearied, at any time — men would follow My path in every way, O Pārtha."

Bhāṣya: If even the Lord withdrew, people would imitate His inaction and be ruined. His tireless activity is purely for the world's protection.

BG 3.24

Withdrawal would collapse the world

उत्सीदेयुरिमे लोका न कुर्यां कर्म चेदहम् ।

सङ्करस्य च कर्ता स्यामुपहन्यामिमाः प्रजाः ॥ ३.२४ ॥

utsīdeyur ime lokā na kuryām karma ced aham |
saṅkarasya ca kartā syām upahanyām imāḥ prajāḥ | |

"If I did not perform action, these worlds would perish; I would be the author of confusion (of duties) and would destroy these beings."

Bhāṣya: The consequence of a leader's withdrawal: social collapse (*saṅkara* = confusion of duties) and ruin of people. Responsibility, not need, drives the wise one's action.

§ 4 · The wise vs. the ignorant; non-agency (3.25–3.29)

BG 3.25 Same action, opposite inner attitude

सक्ताः कर्मण्यविद्वांसो यथा कुर्वन्ति भारत ।

कुर्याद्विद्वांस्तथासक्तश्चिकीर्षुर्लोकसङ्ग्रहम् ॥ ३.२५ ॥

*saktāḥ karmaṇy avidvāṁso yathā kurvanti bhārata |
kuryād vidvāṁs tathāsaktaś cikīrṣur loka-saṅgraham ||*

"As the ignorant act with attachment to work, so should the wise act — but without attachment — desiring the welfare of the world."

Bhāṣya: The outward action of wise and ignorant may look identical; the difference is *inner attachment*. The wise act with the same diligence, detached, for society's good.

BG 3.26 Do not unsettle the minds of the attached

न बुद्धिभेदं जनयेदज्ञानां कर्मसङ्गिनाम् ।

जोषयेत्सर्वकर्माणि विद्वान्युक्तः समाचरन् ॥ ३.२६ ॥

*na buddhi-bhedaṁ janayed ajñānāṁ karma-saṅginām |
joṣayet sarva-karmāṇi vidvān yuktaḥ samācaran ||*

"Let no wise man unsettle the minds of the ignorant attached to action; rather, acting with devotion, he should encourage them in all their work."

Bhāṣya: The knower should not preach "give up action!" to the unqualified — it only confuses them into abandoning duty *without* gaining knowledge. By acting well himself he inspires them. A key point on teaching by fitness (*adhikāra*).

BG 3.27 "I am the doer" is the ego's delusion

प्रकृतेः क्रियमाणानि गुणैः कर्माणि सर्वशः ।

अहङ्कारविमूढात्मा कर्ताहमिति मन्यते ॥ ३.२७ ॥

*prakṛteḥ kriyamāṇāni guṇaiḥ karmāṇi sarvaśaḥ |
ahaṅkāra-vimūḍhātmā kartāham iti manyate ||*

"Actions are in every way performed by the guṇas of prakṛti. But one deluded by ego (*ahaṅkāra*) thinks, 'I am the doer.'"

Bhāṣya: The heart of the non-agency doctrine. All action belongs to *prakṛti* and its guṇas — the Self is a non-doer. Bondage is the false conceit "I am the doer," born of ego. This is the very *avidyā* that knowledge dissolves.

BG 3.28 "The guṇas act upon the guṇas"

तत्त्ववित्तु महाबाहो गुणकर्मविभागयोः ।

गुणा गुणेषु वर्तन्त इति मत्वा न सज्जते ॥ ३.२८ ॥

*tattva-vit tu mahā-bāho guṇa-karma-vibhāgayoḥ |
guṇā guṇeṣu vartanta iti matvā na sajjate ||*

"But he who knows the truth about the divisions of the guṇas and their actions, understanding that 'the guṇas merely act upon the guṇas,' is not attached."

Bhāṣya: The knower sees that "the senses (guṇa-products) move among sense-objects (guṇa-products)" — the Self does nothing. Realizing this, he is unattached: the *internal, epistemic renunciation* — freedom by **knowing** one is not the doer.

प्रकृतेर्गुणसम्मूढाः सज्जन्ते गुणकर्मसु ।
तानकृत्स्नविदो मन्दान्कृत्स्नविन्न विचालयेत् ॥ ३.२९ ॥

prakṛter guṇa-sammūḍhāḥ sajjante guṇa-karmasu |
tān akṛtsna-vido mandān kṛtsna-vin na vicālayet ||

"Those deluded by the guṇas are attached to the actions of the guṇas. The one who knows the whole should not unsettle those of dull, incomplete knowledge."

Bhāṣya: Again the pedagogy of fitness: the fully wise (*kṛtsna-vit*) should not shake the faith of the dull, partially-informed (*manda, akṛtsna-vit*), who cannot yet act without attachment.

§ 5 • Surrender of action & svadharma (3.30–3.35)

BG 3.30 □ Surrender all actions; fight free of fever

मयि सर्वाणि कर्माणि संन्यस्याध्यात्मचेतसा ।

निराशीर्निर्ममो भूत्वा युध्यस्व विगतज्वरः ॥ ३.३० ॥

mayi sarvāṇi karmāṇi saṁnyasyādhyātma-cetasā |
nirāśīr nirmamo bhūtvā yudhyasva vigata-jvaraḥ | |

"Surrendering all actions to Me, with mind fixed on the Self, free from desire and possessiveness, and rid of mental fever — fight!"

Bhāṣya: The practical instruction. Offer all works to the Lord with Self-knowledge (*adhyātma-cetasā*), without craving results (*nirāśīḥ*), without "mine"-ness (*nirmamaḥ*), without the "fever" of grief and anxiety. Karma-yoga's culminating attitude.

BG 3.31 Faith and freedom from cavil

ये मे मतमिदं नित्यमनुतिष्ठन्ति मानवाः ।

श्रद्धावन्तोऽनसूयन्तो मुच्यन्ते तेऽपि कर्मभिः ॥ ३.३१ ॥

ye me matam idaṁ nityam anutiṣṭhanti mānavāḥ |
śraddhāvanto 'nasūyanto mucyante te 'pi karmabhiḥ | |

"Those who constantly practice this teaching of Mine, full of faith and free from cavil, they too are freed from actions (their binding force)."

Bhāṣya: With *śraddhā* (faith) and *anasūyā* (no fault-finding), those who follow this are released from karmic bondage — through the purification and knowledge it produces.

BG 3.32 The carping and non-practicing are lost

ये त्वेतदभ्यसूयन्तो नानुतिष्ठन्ति मे मतम् ।

सर्वज्ञानविमूढांस्तान्चिद्धि नष्टानचेतसः ॥ ३.३२ ॥

ye tv etad abhyasūyanto nānutiṣṭhanti me matam |
sarva-jñāna-vimūḍhāṁs tān viddhi naṣṭān acetasaḥ | |

"But those who carp at this teaching and do not follow it — know them to be deluded in all knowledge, senseless, and lost."

Bhāṣya: The opposite disposition — cavilling and non-practice — dooms one; such people are confused about all wisdom and devoid of discrimination.

BG 3.33 Even the wise follow their nature

सदृशं चेष्टते स्वस्याः प्रकृतेर्ज्ञानवानपि ।

प्रकृतिं यान्ति भूतानि निग्रहः किं करिष्यति ॥ ३.३३ ॥

sadrśaṁ ceṣṭate svasyāḥ prakṛter jñānavān api |
prakṛtiṁ yānti bhūtāni nigrahaḥ kiṁ kariṣyati | |

"Even the wise man acts according to his own nature; beings follow their nature. What will (mere) suppression accomplish?"

Bhāṣya: Conduct flows from one's acquired nature. Forcible restraint alone won't work — this shows the futility of merely *suppressing* the senses without knowledge; real freedom is by wisdom, not violent repression.

BG 3.34 Attraction & aversion are the highway-robbers

इन्द्रियस्येन्द्रियस्यार्थे रागद्वेषौ व्यवस्थितौ ।

तयोर्न वशमागच्छेत्तौ ह्यस्य परिपन्थिनौ ॥ ३.३४ ॥

*indriyasyendriyasyārthe rāga-dveṣau vyavasthitau |
tayor na vaśam āgacchet tau hy asya paripanthinau ||*

"Attraction and aversion are seated in each sense toward its object. One should not come under their sway, for they are one's foes."

Bhāṣya: Reconciling 3.33: you cannot instantly abolish nature, but you must not become a slave to *rāga* (liking) and *dveṣa* (aversion). These two are the real robbers on the path; mastering them is the field of effort.

BG 3.35 Better one's own dharma, though imperfect

श्रेयान्स्वधर्मो विगुणः परधर्मात्स्वनुष्ठितात् ।

स्वधर्मे निधनं श्रेयः परधर्मो भयावहः ॥ ३.३५ ॥

*śreyān sva-dharmo viguṇaḥ para-dharmāt sv-anuṣṭhitāt |
sva-dharme nidhanam śreyaḥ para-dharmo bhayāvahaḥ ||*

"Better one's own duty, though imperfect, than another's duty well-performed. Better death in one's own duty; another's duty brings danger."

Bhāṣya: The famous *svadharma* verse. Follow your *own* ordained duty (Arjuna's, as a warrior) even if flawed, rather than take up another's role. A duty unsuited to one's nature/qualification is spiritually perilous (*bhayāvaha*). Echoed in 18.47.

§ 6 · Desire — the great enemy — and how to slay it (3.36–3.43)

BG 3.36 Arjuna: what compels us to sin?

अर्जुन उवाच ।

अथ केन प्रयुक्तोऽयं पापं चरति पूरुषः ।

अनिच्छन्नपि वार्ष्णेय बलादिव नियोजितः ॥ ३.३६ ॥

*arjuna uvāca | atha kena prayukto 'yaṁ pāpaṁ carati pūruṣaḥ |
anicchann api vārṣṇeya balād iva niyojitaḥ ||*

Arjuna: "By what is a man impelled to commit sin, O Vārṣṇeya, even against his will, as if driven by force?"

Bhāṣya: The pivotal moral question — what *compels* wrongdoing even when unwilling? This sets up Kṛṣṇa's diagnosis of the root enemy.

BG 3.37 It is desire — and anger, born of rajas

श्रीभगवानुवाच ।

काम एष क्रोध एष रजोगुणसमुद्भवः ।

महाशनो महापाप्मा विद्ध्येनमिह वैरिणम् ॥ ३.३७ ॥

*śrī-bhagavān uvāca | kāma eṣa krodha eṣa rajo-guṇa-samudbhavaḥ |
mahāśano mahā-pāpmā viddhy enam iha vairiṇam ||*

The Lord: "It is desire, it is anger, born of the guṇa of rajas — all-devouring, greatly sinful. Know this to be the enemy here."

Bhāṣya: The answer: **kāma (desire)** and its frustrated form, *krodha (anger)*, arising from *rajas*. Insatiable and corrupting, it is *the* enemy. Thwarted desire becomes anger; both share one root.

BG 3.38 Three veils over knowledge

धूमेनाव्रियते वह्निर्यथादर्शो मलेन च ।
यथोल्बेनावृतो गर्भस्तथा तेनेदमावृतम् ॥ ३.३८ ॥

dhūmenāvriyate vahnir yathādarśo malena ca |
yatholbenāvṛto garbhas tathā tenedam āvṛtam | |

"As fire is covered by smoke, a mirror by dust, an embryo by the womb — so is this (knowledge) covered by that (desire)."

Bhāṣya: Three graded veils (light, heavier, densest) show how *kāma* obscures discrimination in varying degrees. Knowledge is ever-present but *veiled*.

BG 3.39 The insatiable fire, enemy of the wise

आवृतं ज्ञानमेतेन ज्ञानिनो नित्यवैरिणा ।
कामरूपेण कौन्तेय दुष्पूरेणानलेन च ॥ ३.३९ ॥

āvṛtaṁ jñānam etena jñānino nitya-vairiṇā |
kāma-rūpeṇa kaunteya duṣpūreṇānalena ca | |

"Knowledge is covered by this constant enemy of the wise, O son of Kuntī — in the form of desire, insatiable like fire."

Bhāṣya: Desire is the *perpetual* enemy even of the discerning; like fire it is never sated by feeding — indulgence only inflames it. Hence it must be conquered, not fed.

BG 3.40 Its strongholds: senses, mind, intellect

इन्द्रियाणि मनो बुद्धिरस्याधिष्ठानमुच्यते ।
एतैर्विमोहयत्येष ज्ञानमावृत्य देहिनम् ॥ ३.४० ॥

indriyāṇi mano buddhir asyādhiṣṭhānam ucyate |
etair vimohayaty eṣa jñānam āvṛtya dehinam | |

"The senses, the mind, and the intellect are said to be its seat; through these it deludes the embodied one, veiling his knowledge."

Bhāṣya: Locating the enemy: desire operates *through* the senses, mind, and intellect. Knowing its strongholds tells us where to fight.

BG 3.41 First control the senses, then slay it

तस्मात्त्वमिन्द्रियाण्यादौ नियम्य भरतर्षभ ।
पाप्मानं प्रजहि ह्येनं ज्ञानविज्ञाननाशनम् ॥ ३.४१ ॥

tasmāt tvam indriyāṇy ādau niyamya bharatarṣabha |
pāpmānaṁ prajahi hy enaṁ jñāna-vijñāna-nāśanam | |

"Therefore, O best of the Bharatas, first control the senses and slay this sinful destroyer of knowledge and realization."

Bhāṣya: The battle plan: *first* master the senses (the outer stronghold), then destroy desire, which ruins both *jñāna* (scriptural knowledge) and *vijñāna* (direct realization).

